

US semiconductor tariffs likely to be further delayed

送信者: EG Geo-technology 受信日時: 2026-09-08 23:26

【メール原文】

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The renewed debate on semiconductor tariffs—with Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick reportedly pushing for action—likely reflects a July milestone in the ongoing Section 232 investigation rather than a shift in policy direction.

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Any tariff push will probably lose momentum in the short term, as Lutnick's influence on White House technology policy appears constrained and an upcoming summit between presidents Donald Trump and Xi Jinping discourages provocative moves in this area.

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If the US eventually does impose semiconductor tariffs, the framework agreement with Taiwan would be the likely template, though key questions on tariff offsets remain unresolved.

Renewed semiconductor tariff discussion is part of a pattern dating back to Liberation Day. Shortly after President Donald Trump announced tariffs on countries around the world on 2 April 2025, the White House announced carve-outs for semiconductors from country-specific duties and launched a Section 232 investigation into the national security effects of semiconductor imports. The conclusion of that investigation was followed by the January 2026 semiconductor proclamation, which created a revenue collection mechanism allowing the US government to take a 25% share of export revenue from high-end AI chips under Section 232 (see: [Taiwan semiconductor deal offers little upside for other trade negotiations](#) , 22 January 2026). The proclamation also required the US trade representative and Commerce to provide an update on 1 July on semiconductor use in US data centers. The completion of this report has renewed discussion about next steps on semiconductor tariffs, providing a fresh opening for Lutnick and other advocates of a broader tariff push within the administration. Media reports on worsening discussions between Commerce and the US tech industry may have further fueled the tariff push narrative.

Eurasia Group's basecase remains that any semiconductor tariff push is likely to fade in the near term. Early this year, the Commerce Department pushed for the release of the tariff announcement but eventually delayed the move to avoid disrupting the Trump-Xi summit in May. With another summit fast approaching in a few weeks, the Commerce Department has likely received another signal to avoid potentially provocative actions ahead of the leaders' meeting.

Moreover, the commerce secretary remains relatively marginalized in White House technology policy debates on issues such as distillation and export restrictions. Without clear backing from Trump, Lutnick is likely to tread carefully. Earlier decisions on export controls appear to have weakened his standing with the president. These included efforts to prohibit US companies from selling chips to data centers that already use Huawei components and a move to expand entity list designations to a large number of subsidiaries of Chinese companies already on this list.

The Taiwan deal provides a template for a tariff regime. Under the January agreement, companies building US capacity can receive duty-free import allowances tied to planned domestic production. During the construction of US facilities, Taiwanese firms can import up to 2.5 times their planned US capacity duty-free, with that level falling to 1.5 times once facilities begin operating. That structure, along with other industry consultations, suggests the administration's core objective is reshoring. Tariff pressure drives investment commitments, which Commerce then converts into quotas or waivers and monitors for compliance. The recent Section 232 polysilicon regime offers a similar model, with Commerce empowered to approve onshoring plans and withdraw relief if commitments are not met.

Tariff offsets for investment commitments will likely kick in before production begins. The Taiwan structure indicates that Commerce is willing to grant prospective tariff relief against planned or committed investment rather than requiring fabs to be operational first. Already announced investments could therefore generate offsets even if capital has not yet been deployed.

Still, a lack of clarity on offsets has hindered administration engagement with the sector. The January proclamation proposed an offset program, but the Commerce Department has yet to define the terms. For instance, when asked how the rate would be calculated and whether a rebate would apply beyond the particular products a company manufactures in the US, officials hesitated to extend the carve-out to materials and equipment needed for factory and production-line construction, a critical component of any reshoring project. Absent a practical and meaningful offer, companies are losing interest in discussions of new investment plans.

Conditions for the debate to return. After the Trump-Xi summit, the question of Section 232 tariffs on semiconductors may return, especially if friction emerges in the bilateral relationship and the Commerce Department develops a workable solution that offers meaningful benefits and gains the White House's support. Formal announcements in the Federal Register or proclamations would be the clearest sign of movement; industry-specific deals with chipmakers would also suggest a final framework is taking shape. The ongoing US-Korea trade negotiation reportedly involves a large investment commitment and could serve as a near-term signpost. If the administration enacts tariffs, it will likely allow a months-long implementation period.

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